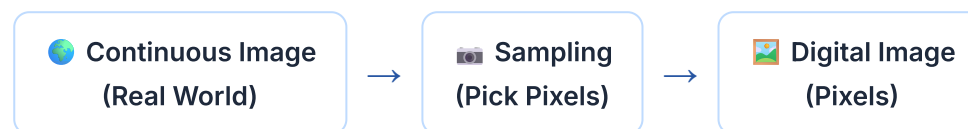


Computer Vision Lab — Sampling & Image Quality

Q: A camera captures an image that appears blurred due to improper sampling. Explain how sampling affects image quality and suggest a method to correct it.

1. What is Sampling?

Sampling is the process of converting a **continuous** (real-world) image into a **digital** image by picking pixel values at regular intervals.



✓ **High Sampling Rate** → More pixels → Better image quality → More details

✗ **Low Sampling Rate** → Fewer pixels → Loss of details → Blurred image

2. Why Does Blurring Occur?

When the sampling rate is too low:

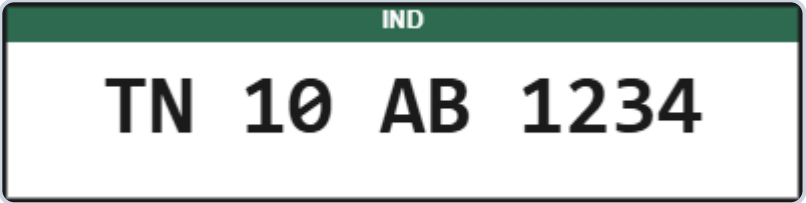
- Fine image details are **lost**

- Neighboring pixels **merge together**
- Edges become **unclear**
- Small objects **disappear**
- The image looks **blurred or blocky**

💡 **Key Point:** More pixels capture more details. Better sampling = Better image quality.

3. Example: Vehicle Number Plate

See how different sampling rates affect a number plate image:



400×100

Sharp

99%

TN 10 AB 1234

Resolution

Quality

OCR Accuracy

OCR Result

Sampling Rate	Resolution (W × H)	Quality	OCR Accuracy
Low	50 × 25 pixels	Blurred	45%
Medium	200 × 100 pixels	Average	82%

Sampling Rate	Resolution (W × H)	Quality	OCR Accuracy
High	400 × 200 pixels	Sharp	99%

4. How to Correct Blurring?

1 **Increase Camera Resolution**

Use a higher-resolution camera. Example: Instead of 640×480, use 1920×1080.

2 **Increase Sampling Rate**

Capture more pixels per unit area. More pixels → Better detail → Clear image.

3 **Use Image Interpolation (Software)**

Resize using: **Bilinear**, **Bicubic**, or **Lanczos** interpolation. *(Improves appearance but cannot recover lost details.)*

4 **Improve Camera Focus**

Proper focus ensures the sampled pixels accurately represent the scene.

5. Real-Life Applications Affected by Poor Sampling



Face Recognition — Face cannot be identified



Medical Imaging — Tumors may be missed

**Self-Driving Cars** — Road signs not detected**QR Scanner** — QR code cannot be decoded**OCR** — Text recognition accuracy drops

6. Python Code — Try It Yourself

Use these OpenCV code snippets in your lab to experiment with sampling and interpolation.



Required Image for Code

Download the sample number plate image to run the code below.

[Download Image](#)

How to Run this Code and See the Output

Step 1: Where to run it?

- **Google Colab / Jupyter Notebook (Recommended for Labs):** Create a new notebook. Upload the `number_plate.jpg` file into the Colab files section. Paste the code into a cell and press Shift+Enter. The output images will appear directly below the cell!
- **Local Python Script (.py):** Create a file named `lab_demo.py` in the exact same folder as the downloaded image. Paste the code into the file, open your terminal/command prompt, and run `python lab_demo.py`.

Step 2: Install Libraries (Only if running locally)

```
pip install opencv-python matplotlib numpy
```

[Copy](#)

Step 3: How to see the output?

- The code uses `plt.show()` which triggers the output visualization.
- **In Colab/Jupyter:** The image will instantly render inside the webpage.
- **Running Locally:** A new desktop window will pop up showing the result. *Note: You must close the popup window for the script to continue running!*

6.1 Read and Display an Image



```
import cv2                                # Import OpenCV library for image processing
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt           # Import Matplotlib for displaying images

# Read the image from the disk into a NumPy array
img = cv2.imread('number_plate.jpg')      # cv2.imread reads the image in BGR (Blue-Green-Red) format
# Convert the BGR image to RGB format since Matplotlib expects RGB
img_rgb = cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB) # This ensures colors look correct when displayed

# Display the image using Matplotlib
plt.imshow(img_rgb)                       # Render the RGB image array
plt.title('Original Image')              # Add a title to the plot window
plt.axis('off')                          # Hide the X and Y axes (ticks and borders) for a clean look
plt.show()                               # Show the actual window on screen

# Print the dimensions of the loaded image
print("Image Shape:", img.shape)         # Outputs (height, width, channels) e.g., (100, 400, 3)
```

6.2 Simulate Low Sampling (Downsample)



```
# Downsample the image to a tiny 50x25 resolution to simulate a very low sampling rate (bad camera sensor)
low_res = cv2.resize(img, (50, 25), interpolation=cv2.INTER_NEAREST) #
print("Low-Res Shape:", low_res.shape) # The image is now only 25 pixels high and 50 pixels wide

# Scale the tiny image back up to 400x200 so we can actually see the blocky pixelation effect on screen
pixelated = cv2.resize(low_res, (400, 200), interpolation=cv2.INTER_NEAREST) # Upscale using Nearest Neighbor to keep

# Create a figure with a specific size (width=10, height=4 inches)
plt.figure(figsize=(10, 4)) # Create a visualization window to hold our images

# Create the left subplot (1 row, 2 columns, 1st position)
plt.subplot(1, 2, 1) # Position this image within a grid layout
plt.imshow(cv2.cvtColor(img, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)) # Display the original, high-quality image
plt.title('Original (High Sampling)') # Set a descriptive title for this plot
plt.axis('off') # Hide axis ticks and coordinates

# Create the right subplot (1 row, 2 columns, 2nd position)
plt.subplot(1, 2, 2) # Position this image within a grid layout
plt.imshow(cv2.cvtColor(pixelated, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)) # Display the blurred/blocky low-sampling image
plt.title('Pixelated (Low Sampling)') # Set a descriptive title for this plot
plt.axis('off') # Hide axis ticks and coordinates
plt.show() # Render both subplots to the screen
```

6.3 Compare Different Sampling Rates



```
# Define a list of different resolutions to test (Low, Medium, High)
sizes = [(50, 25), (200, 100), (400, 200)] # Width x Height tuples
```

```

# Labels for our plot titles
labels = ['Low (50x25)', 'Medium (200x100)', 'High (400x200)'] # Define corresponding text labels

plt.figure(figsize=(14, 4)) # Create a wide figure window

# Loop through each size and label simultaneously
for i, (size, label) in enumerate(zip(sizes, labels)): # Iterate through the parameters
    # Step 1: Downsample the original image to the specific 'size' to simulate the sensor resolution
    small = cv2.resize(img, size, interpolation=cv2.INTER_AREA)

    # Step 2: Upsample it back to 400x200 so we can compare them all at the same physical size
    restored = cv2.resize(small, (400, 200), interpolation=cv2.INTER_NEAREST) # Upsample image

    plt.subplot(1, 3, i + 1) # Create a subplot (1 row, 3 columns, position i+1)
    plt.imshow(cv2.cvtColor(restored, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)) # Show the image
    plt.title(label) # Set the title to the current sampling rate label
    plt.axis('off') # Hide the axis

plt.suptitle('Effect of Different Sampling Rates') # Add a main title for the whole window
plt.tight_layout() # Automatically adjust spacing between plots
plt.show() # Display the final comparison

```

6.4 Correction Using Interpolation Methods

 Copy

```

# Start with a heavily downsampled (blurred) low-resolution image
low_res = cv2.resize(img, (50, 25), interpolation=cv2.INTER_AREA) # Apply resize downsampling

# Define a dictionary of the 4 mathematical interpolation methods OpenCV provides for upscaling

```

```

methods = {
    'Nearest Neighbor': cv2.INTER_NEAREST,    # Fast, but creates blocky pixelated edges
    'Bilinear': cv2.INTER_LINEAR,             # Uses 4 nearby pixels, creates smooth but slightly blurry edges
    'Bicubic': cv2.INTER_CUBIC,               # Uses 16 nearby pixels, creates sharp and smooth edges (Best balance
    'Lanczos': cv2.INTER_LANCZOS4            # Uses math formulas over 8x8 pixels, highest quality but slow
}

plt.figure(figsize=(14, 4))                  # Create a wide figure to fit 4 images

# Loop through our dictionary of methods
for i, (name, method) in enumerate(methods.items()):
    # Iterate through the parameters
    # Here is the correction! Upscale the low-res image using the current mathematical method
    upscaled = cv2.resize(low_res, (400, 200), interpolation=method)

    plt.subplot(1, 4, i + 1)                  # Place image in a 1x4 grid
    plt.imshow(cv2.cvtColor(upscaled, cv2.COLOR_BGR2RGB)) # Convert BGR to RGB and show
    plt.title(name, fontsize=9)               # Label the image with the method name
    plt.axis('off')                          # Hide axis ticks and coordinates

plt.suptitle('Interpolation Methods Comparison') # Set a master title for the entire window
plt.tight_layout()                          # Automatically fix padding and spacing
plt.show()                                  # Display the corrected images side-by-side

```

6.5 Measure Image Quality (PSNR)



```

# PSNR = Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio. It mathematically compares a degraded image to the original. Higher dB is better.
original = cv2.resize(img, (400, 200))      # Set our baseline ground truth image

```



```
# Test 3 different sampling sizes
for label, size in zip(['Low', 'Medium', 'High'], [(50,25), (200,100), (400,200)]): # Iterate through the parameter
    small = cv2.resize(img, size, interpolation=cv2.INTER_AREA) # Simulate sampling
    restored = cv2.resize(small, (400, 200), interpolation=cv2.INTER_CUBIC) # Correct using Bicubic interpolation

    # Calculate the mathematical quality score between the original and the restored image
    psnr = cv2.PSNR(original, restored) # Compute Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio

    print(f"{label} Sampling -> PSNR: {psnr:.2f} dB") # Print the result (e.g., "Low Sampling -> PSNR: 15.2 dB")
```

💡 **Output Example:** Low → ~20 dB (poor), Medium → ~30 dB (okay), High → ~∞ dB (identical)

Conclusion

Improper sampling captures fewer pixels, causing **blurred images** and loss of important details. Increasing the sampling rate (higher resolution) and using proper image acquisition techniques produces **clearer images**, improving the accuracy of computer vision tasks.

Computer Vision Lab · Saveetha School of Engineering

This page/site is developed and maintained by Dr. T. M. Usha